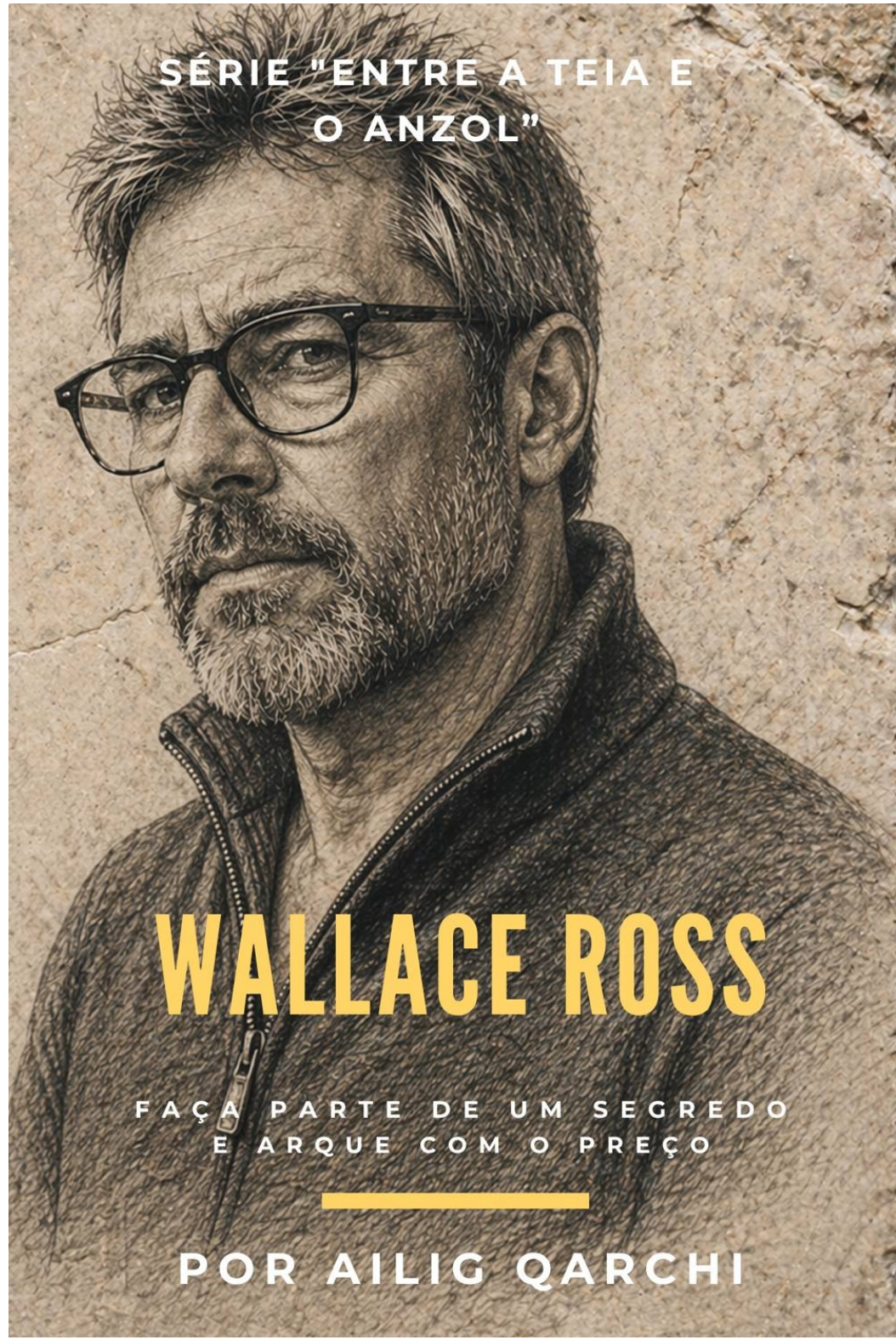

SÉRIE "ENTRE A TEIA E O ANZOL"
WALLACE ROSS
FAÇA PARTE DE UM SEGREDO E ARQUE COM O PREÇO
POR AILIG QARCHI

Between the Web and the Hook series

Wallace Ross

✦

Ailig Qarchi

© 2026 Ailig Qarchi. Free sample: it may be shared freely, unchanged and free of charge.
Translation produced with the help of artificial intelligence.

Prologue

✦

The wind did not blow — it breathed.

It came down the limestone cliffs of Nauru, brushed the thick leaves of the trees and wound its way into the heart of the island, where the earth opened in silence around the well of Ara. The water there was dark as liquid obsidian — as if it did not want anyone to see their own reflection.

Eijebong stood at the edge, her bare feet on the damp rock. Her hair fell to her waist like a night tide, moving with a slowness that did not obey the wind. In her eyes was the deep blue of the ocean that surrounded the island — and something older than any lagoon, something the size of the instant in which the first coral decided to grow.

She was listening. Not with her ears.

The island spoke in tiny cracklings — roots rubbing against the soil, crabs burrowing, the slow breathing of the limestone soaking up the heat of the day. The mineral heart of Nauru pulsed through her. But that day the pulse faltered — almost nothing, just one interval too many between one beat and the next. The kind of silence anyone would recognize as foreign to nature. Eijebong closed her eyes.

“Dataruk,” she called, without a voice.

The name did not echo through the air but through the iwiji that ran beneath the ground like invisible rivers — it spread like a wave that reverberates and fades, never to return the same. Nothing answered.

She reached for Enuwedu. She felt the distant tide, but heavy, muffled, as if under a thick veil.

“Enproe.”

The wind changed direction, nothing more. Gogora, Ikiwoiy, Duguduba, Dagigia, Dedage and Itsi.

One by one, she cast the names into the invisible web that bound the Naauaeron. The thread that had always vibrated was now heavy, sticky, as if the weave of the world were being wrapped in resin. A weight began to grow behind her eyes. Eijebong frowned. She was the island, and the island was her — fused to such a degree that sleep had been taken from her, not chosen. She watched humans sleep on their mats, dozing, snoring, and remembered having once joined her consciousness to women’s to share dreams, appearing among them as a dragonfly. She smiled at the memory. Sleep was a concession granted to mortals; the eternal simply chose not to walk that path — not out of incapacity, but by choice, unless they needed to regulate their own energy.

Even so, her thoughts grew dense, as if they were wading through deep water.

Narwoa.

The name did not come as a word but as a dark memory gliding beneath the sea — a ravenous shark. She touched the ground with the palm of her hand.

The earth answered with a faint shudder.

“No,” she murmured, and this time the sound existed.

She tried to rise completely: to summon the iwiji in a wave, to spread herself through the roots, to wake every stone, every leaf, every creature.

But the iwiji did not run as before — it was as if it moved inside a dream, strangely, though still more naturally than the young women themselves.

The horizon seemed to tilt, and she leaned over the well of Ara, which reflected something that was not in the sky: a dark flicker, a brief fissure on the surface of the water. Eijebong touched her hair and took a deep breath; her knees met the ground. The vegetation around her bowed slightly, as if it recognized the gesture. She tried once more:

“Guard…”

The call dissolved before it was born, her voice almost strangled. The drowsiness, she felt, was an invasion of her consciousness. She understood, in a flash that cut through the torpor: it was not only her, it was the whole network of guardians and vassals. If she fell, they would fall together; if she resisted, perhaps she would only prolong the inevitable. Her fingers sank into the damp earth near the lake, among dead leaves.

“Nauru…” she whispered.

And then, for the first time since she had fused with the island, something cold found room inside her. It was not for herself, but for what would come when the silence was complete.

She sat down slowly. The sky seemed too far away. She lay down beside the well of Ara. Her hair spread over the ground like black roots. The dark water trembled a single time.

Her eyes stayed open for one final instant. There were stars inside them — not the stars of the sky, but the ones that existed before the sky.

Then they closed. The body did not dissolve, did not rot, did not turn to dust — it simply ceased to be there.

The vegetation rose, bending as if in mourning — the leaves whispered their own sorrow, a little less beautiful than before. The wind stopped.

The iwiji of the island sank into a deep stillness, like a tide receding beyond the horizon.

And that night, no guardian answered any call. No wave of Enproe rose, no whirlpool of Enuwedu formed.

No light tore through the darkness, and neither Eijebong nor the guardians of Nauru would be seen or heard for the centuries that followed.

✦

The snow did not fall; it was blown.

Pushed in mechanical spirals by copper towers that glittered beyond the windows of the faculty residence. The Winter Machine roared low and constant, like a tamed animal that never slept. Its pistons, hidden beneath glass domes and exposed gears, exhaled white steam that blended with the clouds. The sky over Young Newcastle was a manufactured grey.

Inside the room, the cold did not enter; it was a warm shelter where he could let his thoughts wander with his eyes closed. Brass pipes ran along the walls like external veins, carrying alchemical heat from the university's central boilers. The room was modest but full of small eccentricities: a shelf of hand-labelled flasks, books stacked in precarious balance, a pocket watch taken apart on the desk, as if it were being studied rather than repaired.

Wallace Ross woke before the alarm.

His eyes opened suddenly, as if his mind had kept working through the night. He lay still for a few seconds, listening. The distant rumble of the Winter Machine. The soft ticking of the pipes, a piece of cutlery touching porcelain in the living room. Thauane was already up.

He turned his face to the window. Snow piled on the sill like too much sugar. The chimneys in the distance vomited steam in uneven rhythms. An airship crossed the sky, slow, its metal hull speckled with ice. Wallace ran a hand over his face.

Twenty-three years old — and already as tired as a man of fifty. He got up. The floor was warm under his bare feet. He took the robe hanging on the chair — heavy fabric, dark brown, a little worn at the sleeves. He did not care about new clothes.

In the living room, Thauane sat sideways on the sofa, one leg tucked under her. Her curly blonde hair fell over her shoulders in untidy waves, too deliberate to be carelessness. Her gold-rimmed glasses caught the bluish light of the screen in front of her.

Her green eyes reflected the movement of the sea.

“Up already?” she asked, without taking her eyes off the screen.

“I didn’t sleep enough to justify waking up,” he answered. She smiled faintly.

On the projector, an old film was playing: The Old Man and the Sea. The black-and-white sea looked vaster than the world outside.

“Is it at the part with the fish?” he asked.

“Not yet. All he has is his pride.”

“Pride is worse.”

She finally looked at him.

“You’ll do fine.”

Wallace looked away.

“I haven’t taken the exam yet.”

“But you’re already afraid of it. That usually means you care.”

He nodded, but did not answer. He went into the bathroom. The steam rose from the shower as if it had been summoned, not released. The water came heated by internal coils, mixed with minerals that left a faint metallic smell in the air. He stood under it longer than he needed to. He was thinking about the exam — a presidential mission, a restricted selection, absolute secrecy, applied chemistry but nothing academic about it. Strategic. That bothered him.

He turned off the shower. The water ran down the tiles in irregular patterns. In front of the fogged mirror, he wiped a strip clear with his palm.

The face that appeared looked older than it was. A slightly curved nose. A firm but narrow chin. Eyes too attentive for someone his age. Thick eyebrows, almost academic in themselves. His brown hair, combed back, insisted on falling forward, as if defying any attempt at order. There was something in him of a stubborn explorer trapped in a professor’s body. If someone drew him, he would look like a scholar from a mysterious city, someone who carried maps nobody else understood. He tilted his head.

“Twenty-three,” he murmured.

It didn’t look it.

He dried himself. He put on the beige dress shirt, the brown waistcoat, the dark wool coat. He slipped the watch into the inside pocket. Before leaving, he took a breath-mint gum from the small box by the sink and began to chew. Strong mint. A slight sting. Mental order begins with a clean mouth, he always said. When he came back to the living room, Thauane was standing, now wearing a navy-blue coat that brought out her eyes. The film had been paused: the old man stared at the horizon, frozen on the screen.

“If it’s like him,” she said, “don’t fight the sea. Understand it.”

Wallace picked up his gloves.

“I’m a chemist. Not a sailor.”

“We’re all sailors when the world decides to become an ocean.”

He laughed, in spite of the tension. They went out.

The corridor of the faculty residence was long and warmed by gas lamps protected by glass domes. Professors hurried by. Some greeted them with restrained nods. There was expectation in the air — something was moving through the corridors like an invisible current.

Outside, the snow creaked under their boots.

The Winter Machine rose to the north of the campus like an industrial cathedral. Exposed gears turned slowly, every tooth coated in ice crystals. Copper towers released steam in measured bursts. The whole city depended on that colossal mechanism.

“Do you think it’s about energy?” Thauane asked as they walked.

“Maybe. Or weapons. Or transport.”

“You don’t like any of those options.”

“No.”

They passed students arguing excitedly. A newspaper pinned to a lamppost announced: Presidency Strengthens Strategic Projects.

Wallace’s chest closed a little, like a door someone was pushing from the other side. Thauane noticed. She touched his hand over the glove.

“Whatever the tide, you’re still you.”

He squeezed back.

The university came into view ahead, towers of dark stone against the white steam rising from the chimneys. Flags fluttered in the artificial wind.

In the distance, the bells rang. It was not only the beginning of a day. It was the beginning of something that had been in motion for a very long time.

And Wallace Ross, chewing mint and insecurity, was walking straight into it. The snow, under hundreds of footsteps, stopped being silent. Wallace and Thauane went down Halewick Street, where the faculty's terraced houses formed an almost identical row of dark brick façades and narrow wrought-iron balconies. The brass plates beside the doors displayed names engraved with excessive precision — academic titles longer than the surnames themselves. Number 14 fell behind them.

On the corner, Bramble & Co. Bakery was already open. Steam escaped through the cracks of the door, carrying the warm smell of bread and roasted coffee. A baker with rolled-up sleeves was sprinkling coarse salt over pretzels that still gleamed.

"We'll come back later," said Thauane, more to herself than to him.

"If I survive the exam."

She raised an eyebrow.

"You're not going to die because of an exam."

"You didn't see the look the rector gave me yesterday."

She laughed softly.

Halewick Street opened onto Gearford Avenue, where elevated tracks crossed overhead like ribs of steel. The electric tram ran there, but they would go on to Wintermere Station to take the university train — faster, less crowded and free for professors. The Winter Machine rose to their left, beyond Bellington Park. Even at that distance, the deep sound of its gears could be felt in the bones. Cylindrical towers joined by iron walkways released steam at calculated intervals. The ice

that formed on the structures was constantly scraped off by small automatons that moved along circular rails.

“It looks bigger every year,” said Thauane.

“Because they raised the pressure,” Wallace answered. “If they don’t maintain it properly, one day…”

“Don’t finish that sentence.”

They crossed the park. The trees were bare, except for white ribbons of ice hanging from the branches. A group of students was arguing near the statue of Sir Alcott Wintermere, founder of Candlestaf’s artificial climate system. The statue held a metal globe wrapped in gears — the symbol of human control over the seasons.

Wallace wondered how long that control would last. Wintermere Station appeared just ahead, a building of glass and cast iron, with tall arches and round clocks at each end. The curved roof gathered snow, which slid slowly off the heated edges.

A lit panel read: Academic Line – Young Newcastle Central. Departure: 07:40. They climbed the stone steps. The floor inside was dry thanks to heated coils set beneath the marble. Professors, researchers and a few administrative staff formed orderly queues in front of the turnstiles.

Wallace took a rectangular card of brushed metal from the inside pocket of his coat. The crest of the University of Young Newcastle was embossed on it, with micro-inscriptions around the central emblem — invisible to the naked eye, but recognized by the sensors.

Thauane did the same, and both held their cards to the reader; with a soft click, the turnstile let them through.

“It still surprises me,” said Thauane, “that they don’t charge us anything.”

“They do,” Wallace answered. “Just in reports, targets and expectations.”

They went down to the platform.

The university train was not luxurious, but it was efficient. Carriages of reinforced steel, wide windows, dark-brown leather seats. Steam pipes ran along the ceiling, providing constant heat. Above the doors, signs listed the departments most common among the passengers: Applied Chemistry, Atmospheric Engineering, Marine Biology, Political Science. They got into the third carriage. There were free seats by the window. Wallace helped Thauane out of her coat and hung his own on the metal rack above the seat. The train set off with a discreet jolt.

The landscape began to slide backwards — the park, the Winter Machine, the snow-covered roofs.

A uniformed attendant came down the aisle pushing a trolley.

“Coffee? Tea? A morning snack?”

Thauane raised her hand.

“Two coffees, please. And the cheese rolls.” The attendant handed them small metal trays with fine porcelain cups and simple sandwiches wrapped in wax paper. Wallace thanked him with a nod. They ate in silence for a few minutes. The train gradually picked up speed, the rhythmic sound of the wheels creating an almost hypnotic cadence. Thauane was the first to speak.

“You dreamed about your father again, didn’t you?”

Wallace didn’t answer right away; he chewed and swallowed.

“How do you know?”

“You frown in a particular way when it’s him.” He let out a breath through his nose.

“It wasn’t exactly a dream. It was… a memory mixed with something else.”

“Drake always turned up in the middle of something else,” she said, biting into her roll. “Never directly.”

Wallace rested his elbow on the small folding table between the seats.

“I should have more clear memories. I have few. Very few.”

“How old were you when he…?”

“Eight.”

She nodded slowly.

The train crossed an iron bridge over the Eastmarch Canal. The water below was partly frozen, with irregular plates floating like fragments of a mirror.

“You look like him when you get serious…” said Thauane.

“I don’t look like anyone.”

“That’s not true.”

He stared at his own reflection in the window for a moment.

“My family was always… out of place.”

“In what sense?”

He took a sip of coffee before answering.

“My grandfather used to say we had ‘too many stories’ for such a short lineage.”

“Too many stories is better than none.”

“Not always.”

She tilted her head.

“What did he talk about?”

Wallace shrugged.

“Old things. People who travelled too much. A surname that wasn’t exactly ours.”

“Ross wasn’t Ross?”

“It was. But before that it was something else.”

Thauane watched the landscape through the window.

“You never wanted to look into it?”

“I did.” He gave a half smile. “It’s just that every time I start looking, something more urgent comes up.” She touched his hand.

“Like a secret presidential exam.”

He laughed, but there was no lightness in the sound.

“Maybe.”

The train slowed as it approached Young Newcastle Central Station. Through the window, the university complex was already visible — towers of black stone, pointed windows, suspended walkways connecting the buildings. Wallace used to buy stracciatella ice cream nearby, from the carts that sold to people coming into the university.

“If this exam takes you far away,” Thauane said carefully, “would you go?”

Wallace didn’t answer immediately. He preferred to look at his hands — a little calloused; the chemicals had eaten at the skin and left scars of old blisters. The train stopped. The doors opened with a hydraulic sigh — Wallace’s favourite part, though he would never admit it.

People began to get off; Thauane noticed that most of them wore indifferent faces, some even sad. Not everyone can smile every day.

Thauane turned her gaze to Wallace, who stayed seated a second longer.

“I don’t know,” he said at last.

Thauane stood up with a sharp look.

“Then find out today.”

They stepped down together onto the university's covered platform. Wallace yawned, the cold air defeating his warm breath. He choked, and Thauane slapped him hard on the back.

"Ow! What was that for?"

"Choking."

"You didn't need to hit that hard…" he said, squinting and pressing his lips together. He looked up at the sky of heavy clouds. The day had barely begun. And it already weighed on him.

CHAPTER I

The Exam and the Mission

✦

On the Second Earth, where history had run along tracks different from those known in other worlds, Faraday Hall was colder than it should have been.

Not because the coils had failed — they wound along the walls as always, giving off a steady heat — but because of the silence. The kind of silence that forms when many educated adults decide not to talk about what they really think.

Wallace stopped in front of the double doors of dark oak. Above them, the crest of the University of Young Newcastle was carved in relief: a flame inside a gear, held up by two metal olive branches. Beside the door, an administrative clerk held a clipboard.

“Name.”

“Wallace Ross.”

The clerk ran a gloved finger down the list.

“Department.”

“Applied Chemistry.”

A tick on the paper.

“Card, please.”

Wallace handed over the metal card. The man held it to a small portable reader. A green light blinked.

“You may go in.”

The door creaked slightly as it opened.

The hall was vast, lit by rows of gas lamps shielded by frosted-glass globes. The desks were arranged in straight lines, spaced far enough apart to prevent any attempt at discreet visual communication. On each desk lay only three items: a notebook of heavy pages bearing the presidential seal in red wax, a standard fountain pen and a sealed envelope.

About thirty professors were already seated. Wallace recognized a few faces, his heart racing.

Professor Helmut Aureal, of Atmospheric Engineering — his moustache trimmed with precision, in the style Wallace had wanted to wear some time ago, until Thauane joked that he already looked old and, with that moustache, could apply for a pension. Doctor Ilyana Morcott, a specialist in applied thermodynamics, known for demolishing arguments with the same efficiency with which she took engines apart.

Wallace had had a terrible experience when their teams joined forces on the last project — there had been no friction between the two of them, but the room caught fire when a micro-reactor exploded, and they lost weeks of notes and materials; and the young professor Adrian Vale, of Structural Physics, with a reputation for never getting a calculation wrong.

Everyone there was good. Very good.

These are the kind of people who don’t need to prove competence on paper, Wallace thought. Maybe that guy at the back of the room — he looked kind of relaxed.

Wallace chose a seat in the fourth row. The noise of chairs being adjusted echoed through the hall like small cracks of tension. At the

back of the room, two men he did not recognize were talking in low voices. They did not wear the university's colours. Their coats were of a stiffer cut, discreet lapels, boots far too polished for an academic setting.

Observers. The clock struck 08:00, the doors closed, and Rector Jorwen came in.

He walked with the posture of someone who carries authority as part of his own anatomy. Grey hair combed back, a gaze too piercing for a man whose role was supposed to be administrative.

"Ladies and gentlemen," he began, without raising his voice.

"Thank you for your punctuality."

A few people coughed discreetly.

"What will take place here today is not a conventional assessment. There will be no reference materials, no communication, no interruptions."

He paused.

"The content of this exam is under presidential secrecy. Any attempt to reproduce, copy or disclose it will result in immediate dismissal and possible prosecution for institutional treason."

The silence deepened — institutional treason, words far too big for a simple selection.

"The envelope in front of you contains additional instructions. Do not open it until I say so."

Wallace felt the weight of his own pulse. The rector walked slowly between the rows.

"Some of you imagine this is about extraordinary funding. Others assume it is a scientific mission in foreign territory. Some are thinking of military applications."

He stopped in the middle of the hall.

“I will neither confirm nor deny any hypothesis.” Helmut Aureal folded his arms.

“Just know that the selected candidate must be willing to operate outside the traditional academic scope.” Operate. The word hung in the air.

“Open the envelopes.”

The collective sound of paper being torn seemed louder than it should have been.

Inside was a sheet bearing the presidential crest and a single printed sentence: “Explain, in technical and practical terms, how to stabilize an unstable energy system in an isolated environment, taking into account cultural, geographical and political variables.” Below it, a series of annexes: topographic maps of a small island, irregular climate records, energy consumption charts, reports of unspecified internal conflicts.

Wallace recognized the shape of the coastline before he recognized the name printed in the lower corner.

Nauru — he frowned.

It was not an ordinary island. Too small to warrant that level of strategic investment. Too far away to be irrelevant. Cultural variables — this was not just chemistry. He turned the page: incomplete data, parts deliberately left out, charts that ended abruptly. Wallace had seen this before: a test of gaps, where knowing formulas was not enough; you had to decide what was missing. He pressed his pen to the paper a little harder than he meant to.

He took a deep breath. He glanced at the other colleagues, careful not to look as if he were cheating.

Helmut was already writing with aggressive speed. Ilyana studied the maps with her head tilted. Adrian Vale sat motionless, eyes fixed

on the ceiling, probably calculating in his head. Wallace began with the obvious.

“Geographical isolation implies logistical dependence.” “Logistical dependence implies political vulnerability.” “An unstable system in an isolated environment cannot rely on frequent external resupply.” He drew a diagram of compact modular reactors — the tedious part. But he stopped. Unstable. The word was not technical in that context. It had been chosen on purpose.

Unstable could mean energy, or population, or ecosystem, or all of it. He went back to the attached cultural reports, with mentions of local traditions, tribal structures and leaders called temonibas.

Why include that in a scientific exam? His pen slipped and fell; he caught it quickly, eyes wide, and shrank even further into his chair.

Because the energy system would affect the society. Or because the society was the system. A small pebble began to roll around inside Wallace’s shoe.

If it were only a technical mission, why demand cultural understanding?

The answer was not pleasant. He began to write again. He proposed a hybrid solution: modular energy infrastructure adapted to existing social structures. Local training. Transfer of knowledge instead of external dependence. But he included a note: Any energy intervention in a culturally sensitive environment must prioritize integration and consent, at the risk of irreversible socio-political destabilization.

He hesitated before writing the last word. Irreversible. Time moved on, and the clock showed 09:30. Some had already finished; others were sweating. Wallace turned to the last page. One additional question, on its own: “If the system fails, would you stay?”

There was no room for calculation there. It was a personal question disguised as a technical one. He looked around. No one seemed comfortable.

Helmut was frowning, and Ilyana sat still, pen suspended. Wallace thought of Thauane, of the Winter Machine, of his father. Of too many stories for a short lineage. He wrote: “Yes.”

Then he added: “Because abandoning an unstable system after external intervention is equivalent to causing it.” He closed the notebook. He leaned back in his chair. The hall seemed smaller now. The rector was walking between the desks again. When he passed Wallace, his eyes rested on the page a second longer than necessary. He did not smile, but something there registered. At 10:00, the pens were collected and the notebooks sealed, without a word of comment.

“The results will be communicated individually,” said Jorwen. “Until then, consider this exam non-existent.” Non-existent — and the doors opened. The air in the corridor seemed warmer than before.

The professors left in small groups, but no one discussed answers. Only vague impressions.

“Too strange…” Adrian Vale murmured as he passed Wallace.

“Agreed,” he answered.

Helmut just shook his head and walked on. Wallace made his way down the stone corridor.

He felt as if he had crossed something that could not be undone. As he left the building, the snow was still falling under the perfect control of the Winter Machine.

Too perfect. He took a deep breath — the exam was over, but it felt as though something had only just begun.

End of the sample

✦

You have read the Prologue and the opening of Chapter I of *Wallace Ross*, translated from the original Portuguese.

The complete book is available in Portuguese on Amazon.

If you liked it, pass it on. This is how this story travels: from hand to hand, like a dandelion seed.

ailigqarchi.com.br

© 2026 Ailig Qarchi. Free sample: it may be shared freely, unchanged and free of charge.
Translation produced with the help of artificial intelligence.